DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Come Back When There Is Gehinnom?

Derech Hashem 2:3:10

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 3, paragraph 10 (continued and concluded) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 10 June 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Gilgul: a second chance before the final verdict

This class continues the discussion of gilgulim begun on Monday. A person dies, and before a final verdict is passed on him in heaven he comes down to this world in a new body, with a new chance. This can explain why a seemingly perfect person suffers: he may be repairing something from a previous life. But it need not mean he did wrong before. He may simply not have done enough, and then Hashem may not make him suffer at all, but give him everything he needs to complete his task. "The variables here are endless."

The Rabbi briefly restated last class's point: unlike tehiyat hametim and the World to Come, gilgul is found in neither Tanakh nor Talmud; it first appears in the Zohar, and the Ramhal brings it because of its large place in the Arizal's Kabbalah.

A comforting explanation

Gilgul is very helpful in explaining hard cases. The Rabbi related that the Hazon Ish would stand up for a child with Down syndrome or autism, explaining that such a soul must have completed almost everything and has only one small thing left to do. "How much can a Down syndrome child do in this world?" He added that we do not even know that such a child is suffering; perhaps the parents are. The same is said when a young child dies: what could the child have done to deserve it? Perhaps he was nearly perfect and had only something very small to finish.

He told a well-known story from Baghdad. Aharon, the son of the mekubal Rabbi Shimon Agassi, was an exceptional young man who died suddenly a few days before his huppah. People were bitterly disappointed with what had happened, and the Ben Ish Hai, in his famous hesped, explained that the young man was a gilgul of someone and had come only to complete what remained. Some explain the same way why a baby dies within thirty days (a nefel), or even a miscarriage: the soul needed only one more taste of this world.

A participant asked whether a child can achieve anything, since children cannot sin. The Rabbi answered that a child is not held responsible before twelve or thirteen and cannot sin, which is why we call children pure, but children can still make higher choices.

Question one: why gilgul if there is Gehinnom?

We learned that Gehinnom cleanses a person. So why send a soul back down? A participant answered: Gehinnom cleans you, but it does not move you to the front row. The Rabbi called this excellent. Say, crudely, a person dies 60% misvot and 40% averot. With a majority of merits he enters the World to Come, but first the bad must be scrubbed away in Gehinnom. He then enters as a 60% person, near the back. Gilgul gives him the added chance to come back, repair, and turn 60 into 100.

He cited a parable to the same effect: one doctor heals by cutting off the diseased limb, but the greater doctor heals without amputating. Gehinnom cleans you but leaves you incomplete; gilgul sends you down on a new regime that cures the illness, so that you can reach the front row.

Question two: why bother now?

If I can always come back, why not enjoy myself in this life and fix it next time? A participant answered that something must be hanging over our heads, and the Rabbi agreed. Rabbi Hayim Vital writes that there is a limit: a soul returns at most three times. So this may be your final opportunity.

Question three: can you end up worse?

A participant asked whether a person could come back and do worse than before, especially since each generation is said to be weaker. Rabbi Hayim Vital gives an interesting answer. The perfected part of a person's identity comes back only as an ibbur, something incidental. Take the 60-40 example: in the next life the unrepaired 40% is what lives and acts, while the 60% is "banked." It is part of you but is not affected. So there is little to lose: if you do well, wonderful; if not, you are left with what you had, unless you do far worse than before.

Rabbi Nahman of Breslov held otherwise. He told his talmidim that if they are asked in heaven whether they want to come back as a gilgul, they should refuse. The Rabbi joked that you would have to work out the risk, and ask whom to follow: according to Rabbi Hayim Vital, you have nothing to lose by coming down.

Which body rises at tehiyat hametim?

The Rabbi posed a question of his own. Suppose a soul lived three lives: once as a Jew in Poland, once as a black Jew in Jamaica, once as a brown Jew from Iraq. At tehiyat hametim, which body rises? He presented three opinions: - Somehow all the bodies will rise; he admitted he does not really understand how. - The last body rises, the one that completed the task. - Since the misvot correspond to the 248 limbs and 365 sinews, each part of the body that was perfected in a given life rises from that life, so the resurrected body is an amalgam of all three.

He then distanced himself: "I don't like all of this. I'm just presenting you the opinions." As the Rambam says of questions about Mashiah, when it happens you will see. "This isn't the fundamentals of Torah. Worry about it when it happens, if it happens."

A participant asked how a person knows what he came to repair. The Rabbi said: whatever you find most difficult, which is what the Vilna Gaon says. What you struggle with most is the part

you need to work on.

The end of paragraph 10, and the reasons so far

The paragraph closes by saying that there are many details of how a person is judged across his lives, but "hasur tamim paolo": the Rock's work is perfect. We cannot grasp the depth of Hashem's wisdom; we know only the general principle that one reason things happen to a person may be that he is a gilgul. The Rabbi added that not everyone accepts gilgulim, and in his opinion the idea crept in from other sources, but the Ramhal accepts it as a way to explain why the righteous suffer.

He then reviewed the explanations learned so far: 1. **Meruk:** cleansing the bruises on the apple, in this world or in Gehinnom. 2. **Your role:** like the servants of the king, each has his task (a partial explanation). 3. **The path you choose:** Hashem gives the rasha the means to continue, and tests the saddik to see if he truly wants it, as with Iyov. 4. **Awakening:** pain that wakes you up, like reviving someone who has fainted. 5. **The saddik and the hasid:** the righteous who suffer for their generation, or for the world. 6. **Gilgul.** He set aside the idea of continuing from one's parents as not really an explanation.

Next time the Ramhal will show that these reasons can contradict each other: cleansing may call for illness while the path a person is on calls for health. After that, Part 2 turns to a new question: is there a difference between Jews and non-Jews?

Summary

- Gilgul is a comforting explanation for children born with disabilities or who die young, as the Hazon Ish and the Ben Ish Hai taught.
- Gehinnom cleans but leaves a person where he was; gilgul lets him raise 60% to 100%.
- Rabbi Hayim Vital limits gilgul to three times and holds that what was perfected is safely "banked"; Rabbi Nahman advised refusing another life.
- Opinions on which body rises at tehiyat hametim are speculative; the Rabbi advised not to dwell on them.
- What you find hardest is what you came to fix (the Vilna Gaon).

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